DAILY READING • 样张

The Whale in the Channel

2026-11-13 · 当天 50 词全部覆盖 · 全文 602 词 · 5 段

短文

At six the tide was dropping, and Gethin had the gate up before the first cars came. Today was the maiden voyage of the Estuary Queen, a ferry three years in the building. The announced 启航时间已公布）">departure had been announced for seven, and by half past six the ramp queue had doubled. Customary as ever, the harbour office sent no written notice, only an active radio watch and a man with a clipboard. Every expectation that morning was of a glorious send-off, speeches, and warm champagne. Instead a grey shape rose in the channel, and the crew had to be roused from the galley. Gethin climbed to the upper deck, where the awning gave a strip of shade and the railing stood bare of paint.

Nobody on the ramp had a concrete answer, for no humpback had come this far upstream in forty years. The animal was in obvious peril, its back scraped raw by the gravel bar at high water. Gethin did not underestimate how fast a crowd on a narrow ramp turns into a hazard. Every few minutes the animal would leap and fall back with a slap that sent a stir through the queue. A vet arrived to say the animal must not be exposed to engine noise for six hours. That single sentence was crucial, since it decided whether the ferry sailed at all. There was no certainty, only a tide table and a toll already showing in empty bays.

The kiosk opened at seven, and its cashier, Mona, found forty people wanting coffee. She took payment in two currencies, since half the passengers came from the opposite bank. Her landlord had raised the rent, so the shelves held only cheap snacks. Her insurance covered fire and flood, and said nothing about a stranded animal. An economical answer was needed, and Mona found one in the storeroom: bottled water. Two boys helped her distribute it while a race played on the television. Formula One cars went round and round, indifferent to the queue outside. At ten the booking system threw a bug that cancelled every seven o'clock reservation. Mona could not compensate anyone, so she wrote each name on a receipt.

By noon the humpback had fame: two television vans, a drone, and a postcard seller. Fishermen did not object to the attention, but they objected to the leaflet's wording. Gethin, who

had no ambition to promote himself on camera, stayed behind the gate. The legal framework was thin, and officials quoted different clauses. One solicitor condemned the port for letting a new ferry sail on a falling tide. A retired teacher, who valued her independence, argued that the crew had acted correctly. The collective decision, taken in a shed behind the office, was to wait for slack water. Two diagrams illustrated how the sandbar shifts each winter. Someone had highlighted the depth figures in yellow.

By four the light had thinned, and Gethin had no inclination to argue. The vocabulary 这头鲸的「词汇」）">whale's vocabulary, the vet said, was mostly clicks we cannot hear. Whilst the queue waited, volunteers began to construct a screen of tarpaulin and poles. The yard that manufactured the ferry sent a spare gangway at five. Reports of its position varied by the hour, and confirmation came at dusk. The occasional car turned onto the ramp, saw the screen, and reversed. There was no certainty certainty whatsoever 毫无把握）">whatsoever that it would find the channel alone. What carried them through was endurance, and a kettle that never went cold. At seven forty the animal moved, slowly, then with long deliberate strokes. The Estuary Queen sailed an hour late, and nobody complained.

解析 · 行间留白，可直接手写

At six the tide was dropping, and Gethin had the gate up before the first cars came. Today was the **maiden voyage** of the Estuary Queen, a ferry three years in the building. The departure had been announced for seven, and by half past six the ramp queue had doubled. Customary as ever, the harbour office sent no written notice, only an active radio watch and a man with a clipboard. Every expectation that morning was of a glorious send-off, speeches, and warm champagne. Instead a grey shape rose in the channel, and the crew had to be roused from the galley. Gethin climbed to the upper deck, where the awning gave **a strip of shade** and the railing stood **bare of paint**.

> **maiden voyage** 处女航，首航 maiden 本义「少女」，作定语表「首次的」，常见 maiden voyage / flight / name。
> **a strip of shade** 一小条阴凉 strip 指狭长的一条，常与 narrow / thin 连用；shade 不可数，不说 a shade。
> **bare of paint** 光秃秃的，漆都掉光了 bare of + 名词 = 「没有…的」，比 with no paint 书面；barely 是「几乎不」，别混。

Nobody on the ramp had a concrete answer, for no humpback had come this far upstream in forty years. The animal was **in obvious peril**, its back scraped raw by the gravel bar **at high water**. Gethin did not underestimate how fast a crowd on a narrow ramp turns into a hazard. Every few minutes the animal would leap and fall back with a slap that **sent a stir through** the queue. A vet arrived to say the animal must not be exposed to engine noise for six hours. That single sentence was crucial, since it decided whether the ferry sailed at all. There was no certainty, only a tide table and a toll already showing in empty bays.

> **in obvious peril** 处境明显危险 peril 比 danger 正式，固定 in peril / at one's peril，修饰语插在 in 与 peril 之间。
> **at high water** 在高潮位时 水位固定说法不加冠词：at high water / at low water；说潮水本身才用 the tide is high。
> **sent a stir through** 在…中引起一阵骚动 stir 作名词指「骚动」，搭配 cause / send a stir through + 人群，介词固定用 through。

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> **in two currencies** 用两种货币 表示计价或支付所用货币用 in：pay in dollars，不用 with。
> **An economical answer** 省钱的办法 economical 指「省钱的」，修饰人或方案；economic 是「经济上的」，不可互换。
> **threw a bug** 抛出个程序错误 口语 throw 可接 error / bug，指系统报错；正式文档多用 cause a bug。

By noon the humpback had fame: two television vans, a drone, and a postcard seller. Fishermen **did not object to** the attention, but they objected to the leaflet's wording. Gethin, who had no ambition to promote himself on camera, stayed behind the gate. The legal framework was thin, and officials quoted different clauses. One solicitor condemned the port for letting a new ferry sail on a falling tide. A retired teacher, who valued her independence, argued that the crew had acted correctly. **The collective decision**, taken in a shed behind the office, was to wait for slack water. Two diagrams illustrated how the sandbar shifts each winter. Someone had highlighted the depth figures in yellow.

> **did not object to** 不反对… object 作动词必带 to，后接名词或动名词：object to sb doing sth。
> **The collective decision** 集体决定 collective 修饰决定、责任，强调群体共同作出；the collective 指集体企业。

By four the light had thinned, and Gethin had **no inclination to** argue. The whale's vocabulary, the vet said, was mostly clicks we cannot hear. Whilst the queue waited, volunteers began to construct a screen of tarpaulin and poles. The yard that manufactured the ferry sent a spare gangway at five. Reports of its position varied by the hour, and confirmation came at dusk. The occasional car turned onto the ramp, saw the screen, and reversed. There was **no certainty whatsoever** that it would find the channel alone. What carried them through was endurance, and a kettle that never went cold. At seven forty the animal moved, slowly, then with long deliberate strokes. The Estuary Queen sailed an hour late, and nobody complained.

> **no inclination to** 没心思 / 没意愿做… inclination 接 to do 或 towards sth；have no inclination to 比 do not want 委婉。
> **no certainty whatsoever** 毫无把握 whatsoever 只用于否定或疑问句，放名词后加强语气，相当于 at all。

译文

六点，潮水正在退，Gethin 在第一辆车到之前就把闸杆抬了起来。今天是「河口女王号」的首航，这条渡轮造了三年。启航公布在七点，而六点半时坡道上的队伍已经翻了一倍。港务处照老规矩没发任何书面通知，只开了个一直在通的电台频道。那天早上所有人预期的都是一场风光的送行、讲话和温吞的香槟。结果航道里浮起一个灰色的影子，船员得从厨房里被叫上来。Gethin 爬上上层甲板，那里的遮阳篷还留着一小条阴凉，栏杆上的漆早掉光了。

坡道上没人能给出一个具体的答案，因为四十年来没有座头鲸游到这么上游的地方。那头动物处境明显危险，它在高潮位越过沙砾坝时把背磨得血肉模糊。Gethin 没有低估一窄条坡道上的人流多快就会变成危险。每隔几分钟它跳起来又砸下去，一声闷响在队伍里引起一阵骚动。一位兽医赶到，说接下来六小时它绝不能接触发动机噪音。这一句话至关重要，因为它决定了渡轮到底还开不开。没有人有把握，只有一张潮汐表和一份已经体现在空车位上的损失。

小卖部七点开门，收银员 Mona 一开门就发现四十个人等着咖啡。她收两种货币，因为一半乘客来自对岸。房东涨了租，所以货架上只有便宜的零食。她的保险保火灾和洪水，对一头搁浅的动物只字未提。得有个省钱的解决办法，Mona 在储藏室里找到了：瓶装水。两个男孩帮她把水分发下去，电视里正播着一场比赛。一级方程式赛车一圈一圈地跑，完全不管门外排着的队。十点，订票系统抛出个程序错误，把七点那班的预订全取消了。Mona 谁也赔不了，只好把每个名字写在收据上。

到中午这头座头鲸已经出了名：两台电视转播车、一架无人机、一个卖明信片的人。渔民并不反对被关注，他们反对的是传单上的措辞。Gethin 没有上镜出名的野心，就一直待在闸门后面。这种事可依的法律框架很薄，官员们引的条款各不相同。一位律师谴责港方让一条新船在退潮时出海。一位退休教师看重独立性，认为船员做得对。在售票处后面的棚子里做出的集体决定是：等平潮。两张示意图说明了沙洲每年冬天怎么移动。有人早先用黄笔把水深数字标了出来。

到四点光线已经淡了，Gethin 也没力气再跟谁争。兽医说这头鲸的「词汇」主要是我们听不见的咔嗒声。趁队伍还在等，志愿者开始用帆布和杆子搭起一道遮挡。造这条船的船厂五点送来一条备用舷梯。它的位置每小时都在变，确认消息到黄昏才来。偶尔还有车拐上坡道，看见挡布又倒回去。它能不能自己找到航道，完全没有把握。撑住他们的是耐力，还有一只从没凉过的水壶。七点四十，那头动物动了，先是慢，然后划出长长的一下一下。河口女王号晚了一个小时开航，没人抱怨。